

Impact: Medium Difficulty: Easy Misuse risk: Low

WHY IT WORKS

Questions put people in the role of expert about their own experience — this is intrinsically motivating. A genuine curiosity question shifts the dynamic from you performing to them contributing, which deepens both rapport and your actual understanding.

WHAT IT IS (AND ISN'T)

- Not an interrogation — one question, answered fully, beats five fired in a row.
- Not a rhetorical move — a question with a preferred answer baked in is a statement in disguise.
- It is a genuine attempt to be surprised by the answer.

THE PAYOFF

How it lands: Being asked a real question by you feels like being taken seriously.

Principle: People are drawn to those who make them the expert — curiosity flips the spotlight and deepens both trust and your information.

What you gain

- Information nobody volunteers to people who only broadcast
- Conversations that open up instead of winding down
- Quiet people who start contributing when asked directly
- Positions understood before you commit to opposing them
- Rapport built on their favourite subject: their own experience

Why most people fail at it

- Their questions are steering devices, and people can feel the rails.
- They ask, then answer it themselves before the other person can.
- They fire questions in bursts, which feels like cross-examination.
- They ask only what they already know the answer to, so nothing is learned.

CORE FORMULA

Ask from genuine interest -> Open-ended -> Follow up on what they said

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Ask one question in your next conversation that you are genuinely curious about — not to make a point, not to steer, just to understand.

BEST FOR

- Building genuine relationships
- Understanding someone's position before responding
- Drawing out quiet people in group settings
- Getting better information before making decisions

METHOD, STEP BY STEP

1. Ask — Ask from genuine interest

Check your motive before the question leaves your mouth: is this to understand, or to steer? If you already have the answer you want, it is not curiosity.

Steering: 'Wouldn't it be simpler to just do it my way?'

Curious: 'What does your way handle that the simple version would not?'

2. Open — Keep it open-ended

Start with what or how, and leave room for an answer you did not predict. Yes-or-no questions collect confirmations; open ones collect information.

Closed: 'Did the launch go okay?'

Open: 'What surprised you most about the launch?'

3. Follow — Follow up on what they said

Build the next question from their actual words, not from your prepared list. One good follow-up proves you listened better than ten fresh questions.

Scripted: 'Interesting. Next question: where do you see yourself in five years?'

Following: 'You said it was a gut call — what was your gut reacting to?'

FIELD TIP

Ask the question you do not know the answer to.

Most questions in meetings are moves — leading, testing, scoring. The rarest and most powerful kind is one where you genuinely cannot predict the reply. Ask one of those and then be quiet; the silence is where the real answer arrives.

Situation: A colleague proposes an approach you would never have chosen.

Don't: 'Don't you think that's a bit risky?'

Do: 'What made that the front-runner for you? I want to understand it before I react.'

PHRASE BANK

Curiosity Openers · Questions from genuine interest

- "What made you want to do it that way?"
- "How did you arrive at that?"
- "What is the part that worries you most about this?"
- "What would need to be true for you to change your view on that?"
- "What am I missing from my read of this?"
- "What has your experience of this actually been like?"
- "What is the thing you are not saying?"
- "If you had to name the real issue, what would it be?"

Follow-Up Questions · Going deeper on what they said

- "Say more about that."
- "What do you mean when you say X?"
- "Can you give me an example?"
- "What happened next?"
- "What was that like for you?"
- "How long has that been the case?"

Quick Curiosity · Small questions that open doors

- "What happened there?"
- "How come?"
- "What is behind that?"
- "And then what?"
- "What is the story there?"
- "Compared to what?"

Professional Curiosity · Better information before decisions

- "What would change your estimate?"
- "What did you consider and reject before landing on this?"
- "Where is this most likely to break?"
- "What does the data not show us?"
- "Who disagrees with this, and what is their strongest point?"

- "If this fails in six months, what will the reason have been?"

Curiosity Under Fire · Asking instead of defending

- "Before I respond — what is the strongest version of your concern?"
- "What would I need to show you for this to feel safe?"
- "Help me see what you are seeing, because we are reading this differently."
- "What is at stake for you in this that I might be missing?"
- "You clearly feel strongly about this. What is underneath that?"
- "What is the question you think I am avoiding?"

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Rhetorical question that is really a statement: 'Don't you think X?'
Better: What do you think about X?
Best: Open, genuinely curious question with no preferred answer baked in.
2. Weak: Rapid-fire questions that feel like an interrogation
Better: I have a few questions — let me start with the most important one.
Best: One question. Let them answer fully. Follow up on what they actually said.
3. Weak: Asking a question and then answering it yourself
Better: What is your view? I have mine but I want yours first.
Best: Ask and then stay quiet. Let them actually answer.

DECISION TREE

If You want to ask a question but have an agenda

Check: are you asking to understand, or to lead them somewhere? Adjust accordingly.
"I want to understand this before I have a view on it."

If Someone gives a short answer you want to expand

Use a simple open follow-up.
"Tell me more about that."

If You are in a group and someone is not speaking

Direct a specific curiosity question to them.
"I was curious to hear your read on this — you have been thinking about it longer than most of us."

If You ask a question and they deflect

Do not chase it. Ask something adjacent that is easier to answer.
"What is the part you can answer?"

SCENARIOS

Someone proposes an idea you want to understand before judging

Ask how they arrived at it before you respond. — "How did you land on that approach?"

Interview or assessment: listening for what is not being said

Ask for the real version beneath the polished one. — "If you could be honest about what was hard in that, what would you say?"

Networking: making a connection feel real

Ask one question you are genuinely interested in the answer to. — "What is the part of your work that most people misunderstand?"

Conflict: trying to understand their position before responding

Ask before you explain your view. — "Help me understand where you are coming from before I respond."

WORKED EXAMPLE

Without the technique

- (You share your own view at length for several minutes)
- (The other person politely waits, contributes little, leaves feeling talked at)

With the technique

You: What made you decide to take that approach rather than the alternative?

Colleague: Honestly, it was a gut call — but here's the reasoning behind it.

(Conversation opens up; you learn something you would not have otherwise known)

COMMON MISTAKES

The statement dressed as a question

Sounds like: 'Don't you think we should have started earlier?'

Better: 'What would you change about how we started?'

Answering your own question

Sounds like: 'What do you think? Because personally I reckon...'

Better: Ask, then stay silent until they have finished — however long that takes.

The rapid-fire round

Sounds like: 'Why that? And when? And who signed it off? And what about the budget?'

Better: One question at a time. Let each answer breathe before the next.

Performing interest

Sounds like: 'Mm, fascinating.' (said while composing your reply)

Better: Ask only when you can give the answer your full attention — otherwise wait.

Chasing a deflection

Sounds like: 'No but really, tell me, you can tell me, why won't you tell me?'

Better: 'No pressure at all — what is the part you can talk about?'

READING THE ROOM

Signs it is working

- People say more than they usually would.
- You learn something you did not expect.
- Conversations feel alive rather than scripted.
- You genuinely enjoy the conversation.

Signs to adjust

- Your questions feel like interrogation.
- You are asking to steer, not to understand.
- You keep interrupting before they have finished answering.
- You are asking questions you already know the answer to.

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When the other person has clearly signalled they do not want to discuss the topic further.
- In time-pressured situations where questions derail rather than deepen.
- When used to gather information while performing interest — the inauthenticity will eventually surface.

RECOVERY LINES

Best line: 'That was a leading question — let me ask the honest version.'

- "That was a leading question — let me ask the honest version."
- "I just answered my own question. What were you actually going to say?"
- "That came out like a cross-examination. I am genuinely just curious."
- "I interrupted your answer with my next question. Go back — I want the full version."
- "I asked and did not really listen. Can you say that again for me?"
- "That question had my opinion hiding inside it. Forget the question — what is your actual view?"

TECHNIQUE CHAINS

Understand-first chain

Curiosity question -> follow up on the answer -> summarise what you heard -> only then give your view

How did you land on this approach?

You said the deadline drove it — what would you do with two more weeks?

So it is a trade you made knowingly, not an oversight. That changes my read.

Here is my one concern, now that I understand the shape of it.

Drawing-out chain

Direct the question to the quiet person -> wait fully -> follow up on their words -> credit the contribution

Sam, you have run more of these than anyone here — what are we missing?

(Wait. Do not rescue the silence.)

Say more about the supplier point — that has not come up before.

That is the most useful thing said in this meeting so far.

RELATED TECHNIQUES

TC001 — Live Thread Follow-Ups

Live Thread Follow-Ups is curiosity applied in the moment — picking up the thread they just offered instead of starting your own.

TC029 — Strategic Silence

Strategic Silence is the second half of every good question — the answer arrives in the gap you refuse to fill.

TC027 — Permission-Based Advice

Permission-Based Advice keeps curiosity honest — you ask to understand first, and offer advice only when it is invited.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — One real question

Ask one question today that you are genuinely curious about. Note what you learn.

Day 2 — Follow up on the answer

Ask a follow-up question based on what they actually said — not a prepared question.

Day 3 — No agenda test

Ask a question with no preferred answer. Let their response surprise you.

Day 4 — Quiet voices

In a group setting, direct one curiosity question to someone who has been quiet.

Day 5 — Depth question

Ask a question that goes one level deeper than the surface topic.

Day 6 — Stay quiet after asking

Ask a question and then stay completely quiet until they are fully done answering.

Day 7 — Calibration

Did you learn something surprising this week? Did any conversations open up in a way they would not have otherwise?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I ask from genuine curiosity rather than to make a point?
- Was my question open-ended — not a rhetorical statement?
- Did I follow up on what they actually said?
- Did I stay quiet after asking and let them answer fully?
- Did I ask one question at a time?
- Did I avoid answering my own question?
- Did I learn something I did not already know?